약국에서 증상 말하기: 머리가 지끈지끈, 목이 따끔따끔

Learn ten Korean mimetic words (의태어) that describe how your body feels, so you can understand and explain symptoms at a pharmacy or clinic.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, you can read a short symptom note or conversation and use its mimetic words to find what hurts and how it hurts. You can also describe one of your own symptoms with the right mimetic word.

1 WORDS FOR HOW IT HURTS

1	**지끈지끈** (pounding (head))	A heavy, pounding headache that keeps coming back. 예: 시끄러운 데 오래 있었더니 머리가 지끈지끈해요.
2	**욱신욱신** (throbbing ache)	A deep ache that pulses, often in muscles, joints, or teeth. 예: 어제 이삿짐을 날랐더니 온몸이 욱신욱신해요.
3	**콕콕 (쑤시다)** (sharp, stabbing)	A sharp pain at one small point, like a needle. 예: 뛰고 나니까 옆구리가 콕콕 쑤셔요.
4	**따끔따끔** (stinging)	A small, sharp sting, often in the throat or on the skin. 예: 침을 삼킬 때마다 목이 따끔따끔해요.
5	**울렁울렁** (queasy)	Your stomach feels like it is moving, and you feel sick. 예: 버스에서 휴대폰을 봤더니 속이 울렁울렁해요.
6	**으슬으슬 (춥다)** (chilly, shivery)	You feel cold inside, often when a cold is starting. 예: 비를 맞고 왔더니 몸이 으슬으슬 추워요.
7	**빙빙 (돌다)** (spinning (dizzy))	Everything seems to turn around and around. 예: 너무 어지러워서 눈앞이 빙빙 돌아요.
8	**퉁퉁 (붓다)** (puffed up, swollen)	A body part looks big and swollen. 예: 밤에 라면을 먹고 잤더니 얼굴이 퉁퉁 부었어요.
9	**화끈화끈** (burning hot)	Skin or a body part feels hot, like it is burning. 예: 햇볕에 탄 어깨가 화끈화끈해요.
10	**근질근질** (itchy)	You keep wanting to scratch. 예: 모기에 물린 데가 근질근질해요.

2 READING TIP: WHERE + HOW

Look at the noun with 이/가 first: it tells you where (머리가, 목이, 속이). The mimetic word after it tells you how it feels. Most mimetic words are followed by -해요 (따끔따끔 + 해요 → 따끔따끔해요). Some usually go with one verb: 콕콕 쑤셔요, 으슬으슬 추워요, 빙빙 돌아요, 퉁퉁 부었어요.

In English you might say 'a sharp pain' or 'a dull ache.' In Korean, one mimetic word often does this job, and doctors and pharmacists use these words too. The repeated sound (지끈지끈) shows that the feeling keeps coming back.

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3 TELLING A PHARMACIST YOUR SYMPTOMS

1 어디가: 머리가, 목이, 속이
(Say where it hurts.)
→
2 어떻게: 지끈지끈, 따끔따끔, 울렁울
(Say how it feels with a mimetic word.)
→
3 언제부터: 어제부터, 아침부터
(Say since when.)
→
4 다른 증상: 열이 나요, 기침을 해요
(Add any other symptoms.)

Koreans use these words every day at pharmacies, at clinics, and when they talk about their health with friends.

4 YOUR TURN

READ AND DESCRIBE SYMPTOMS
Use the word list and the reading tip to choose, find, or write the right mimetic word for each symptom.

1 Choose the right word:
①감기에 걸렸는지 오후부터 몸이 (으슬으슬 / 퉁퉁) 추워요.
②매운 떡볶이를 먹었더니 입술이 (화끈화끈 / 빙빙)해요.
③배를 오래 탔더니 속이 (근질근질 / 울렁울렁)해요.

2 Read the note and answer in Korean:
「그저께부터 목이 따끔따끔하고, 오늘 아침부터는 귀가 욱신욱신해요. 열은 없어요.」
①Which part stings?
②Which part throbs?

3 Answer Yes or No:
① 「다리가 퉁퉁 부었어요」 means your legs are swollen.
② 「세상이 빙빙 도는 것 같아요」 means your eyes are itchy.
③ 「손가락이 근질근질해요」 means your finger itches.
④ 「발목이 콕콕 쑤셔요」 means a dull, heavy pain all over.

4 Fill in the blank with the word for a throbbing ache:
사랑니를 뽑은 잇몸이 밤새 ____ 아팠어요.

5 Answer in Korean: The pharmacist asks 「어디가 불편하세요?」 Tell them your head has been pounding since last night.

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① 으슬으슬 ② 화끈화끈 ③ 울렁울렁
2) ① 목 ② 귀
3) ① Yes ② No (it means you feel dizzy) ③ Yes ④ No (it means a sharp, stabbing pain)
4) 욱신욱신
5) 어젯밤부터 머리가 지끈지끈 아파요. (어젯밤부터 머리가 지끈지끈해요.)

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